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THE SECOND WAVE AND KUMBHA MELA

14 FEBRUARY 2021

INDIA | 1,40,217 ACTIVE CASES | 1,56,872 DEATHS | 84 LAKH VACCINE DOSES

WORLD | 16,434,660 ACTIVE CASES | 25,38,664 DEATHS | 9.9 CRORE VACCINE DOSES

Meanwhile, doctors across the state of Maharashtra were noticing a sudden rise in COVID-19-test positivity rate amongst patients they were attending to during their daily practice—a majority of these patients were asymptomatic and would have gone undetected had they not presented themselves at clinics for non-COVID-related medical attendance. They began talking in hushed circles about the possibility of a looming wave. At around the same time, oddly, three districts in the state of the Vidarbha region—Amravati, Akola and Yavatmal—began to see a steep spike in the number of new infections. Amravati and Akola began to register an average of 1,000 new infections daily causing an alert in the state government machinery.

The Maharashtra COVID-19 Task Force set up in the early days of the pandemic by Chief Minister Uddhav Thackeray's government was closely evaluating the evolving situation. The experts in the task force were very well expecting a second wave; however, they had thought that it would have occurred in December 2020 or January 2021. They advised the Health Department to send samples from these high-caseload districts for genome sequencing without further delay. By the third week of February, samples from Amravati, Yavatmal and Satara showed a common mutation which was different from the original strain of the virus but not similar to the ones recently found in the UK, South Africa or Brazil. To make matters